

RECOGNITION ON HIS OWN TERMS: TRUMAN, AZEC, AND THE STATE OF ISRAEL

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At 6:11 p.m. on May 14th, 1948, just eleven minutes after Ben-Gurion declared the State of Israel's independence, the White House published a statement recognizing the new Jewish state as de facto. The timing was exact. Days prior, Secretary of State George Marshall, an accomplished general in Truman's administration, clearly warned the president that recognizing Israel would mean a vote against Truman. Marshall's department as a whole was against the recognition. Arab nations threatened a third world war. Regardless, Truman signed. Contesting explanations are all insufficient, standalone: moral duty from the Holocaust, pressure from pro-Israel groups in the Oval Office, primarily the American Zionist Emergency Council (AZEC), or electoral schemes preceding the 1948 presidential elections. While each is partially true, none suffices to explain his decision. Harry S. Truman's recognition of Israel was not a submission to Rabbi Silver and AZEC's statehood campaign, but a strategic play of his own presidential power. Three forces converged on his decision: the AZEC lobby's structured campaign, a State Department working to reverse his foreign policy, and his own inherited moral standings set by Woodrow Wilson, evangelical upbringing, and post-Holocaust moral conviction. Truman, who had deliberately avoided commitment throughout 1946-47, took account of all those pressures and set his own terms on the decision, acting over explicit warnings from his own Secretary of State, George Marshall.

Even before President Harry S. Truman embarked on his White House political career, the gears sending Palestine into partition had been set into motion. In 1917, Arthur Balfour wrote to Lord Rothschild declaring British endorsement of "a national home for the Jewish people ... in Palestine", a commitment backed by then-President Woodrow Wilson, establishing a precedent of American presidents acting in accordance with the ambitions of Zionist leaders – at the time Chaim Weizmann and Ben-Gurion – an expectation Truman directly inherits. While in 1922, the Churchill White Paper restated British dedication, it noted that calling for legislative action towards establishing the state while considering Arab displacement. This equivocation would define global political action for

the following two decades. By 1942, with the Holocaust underway, world Zionist leaders assembled in New York for the Biltmore Conference, concretizing their demands for “the gates of Palestine be opened ... and that Palestine be established as a Jewish Commonwealth integrated in the structure of the new democratic world.” Ben-Gurion provocatively hoped the horrors of the Holocaust would become a “fertile force” for Zionism, pressuring the inevitable into creation. That pressure cohered on November 29, 1947, when the UNGA – and the United States, among many – voted in favor of Resolution 181(II), partitioning Palestine into two distinct Jewish and Arab states, marking America’s vote as formal support of a Jewish state half a year before Truman recognised Israel.

Truman did not have the luxury to approach the Palestine question on a blank slate. The circumstances that he inherited – presidential precedent, his evangelical Christian upbringing, and the moral crisis of the Holocaust – made neutrality impossible. President Wilson’s tradition of sympathy from the Oval Office towards advocates of Jewish statehood was reinforced by Louis Brandeis, who had implemented pro-Zionist sentiments within the highest echelons of American politics, long before Truman engaged in politics. His religious background furthered the biases he inherited; “President Harry Truman was sympathetic to Zionism because of his evangelical Christian upbringing”. This associated him with the broader cultural movement “improving” the image of American Jews from “outsiders” to “insiders” through Biblical texts and Christian Zionism. Additionally, the Holocaust gave a second, more policy-based motive, honed by the 1945 Harrison Report, which found that “as matters now stand, we appear to be treating the Jews as Nazis treated them”. Forced to face these startling findings, Truman declared the DP crisis an “American problem,” involving the United States directly in the Palestine question and concurrently triggering a State Department deeply concerned with the foreign ramifications of that statement. These inherited convictions set the baseline for his morals, but were also the most politically tested point in his presidency.

In the two years preceding recognition, the pro-Zionist lobby launched the most sustained pressure Truman received from any constituency, but Truman deliberately allowed that pressure so that he could resist it, not submit. Silver and AZEC used newspaper advertisements, petition drives, mass rallies, and the implicit threat of Jewish vote in swing cities to overwhelm Truman, leveraging the immense magnitude to force his attention. By early 1948, the number of advertisements and letters sent to the White House was simply unavoidable. “The pro-Zionist lobby (i.e., AZEC) truly came into its own during the Truman presidency”, and managed to convince “a substantial number of citizens and leaders

to join their lobbying efforts and win support from national and local politicians.” Using AZEC’s connections across many government branches, Silver used the Jewish bloc as electoral leverage in the 1948 presidential elections. Considering Truman’s unstable campaign even as the incumbent president, he could not bear that. Truman himself acknowledged the restlessness of this campaign in a correspondence to Congressman Klein: “I don’t think there has ever been any more lobbying and pulling and hauling than has been carried on by the Jews in this Palestine difficulty with which we have been faced.” Contrastingly, his reflection in his *Memoirs* six years later indicates a divergent narrative, saying that the “persistence of a few of the extreme Zionist leaders — actuated by political motives and engaging in political threats — disturbed and annoyed” him. Truman’s frustration was mainly directed at Rabbi Silver and the AZEC leadership, whose aggressive tactics solidified his determination to act on his own terms. However, the pattern of registering pressure without submitting to it first emerges to the public a year before recognition.

On the eve of Yom Kippur 1946, Truman issued a statement strongly supporting the admission of 100,000 displaced Jews into Palestine, and “publicly lent his backing to the creation of a “viable” Jewish state in Palestine, the most pro-Zionist statement ever made by a president.” While on the surface, it sounds like a pro-Zionist comment, Truman withheld any concrete commitments to the cause, a trait that would characterize his behavior through 1947. Considering that it was issued just before a midterm election cycle where Jewish votes in major metropolitan cities could easily sway results, this was not the electoral lifeline Truman was looking for. The Democrats lost control of both the House and the Senate. Yet, Truman himself reaped the benefits with minimal commitments, securing Jewish-American amiability for the 1948 elections. This transactional sentiment he conveys with the American Jewry clearly shows in his correspondence with Congressman Klein, when Truman states that he had “no objection to their lobbying – neither [has he] any objection to the Arabs doing so if they feel like it, but, in neither case, does it affect [his] decisions or judgement.” The Yom Kippur statement was not going towards recognition, and was instead Truman’s maneuver, attempting to buy time while he waited for a situation that would let him act on his own terms. But public deviation alone could not answer the pressure he faced from within his administration, from the people who reached him daily.

While the external pressure campaign launched by organizations like AZEC meaningfully shaped Truman’s thoughts on the Palestine question, more important were the Jewish connections within it. Inside the White House, a small circle of pro-Zionist

advisors held daily access to Truman and could reformulate Palestine as a moral question, circumventing the State Department without forcing Truman to overrule his diplomats in public or cause scandals. The three figures with such internal direct access to Truman – namely David Niles, Clark Clifford, and Max Lowenthal – were so influential that Loy Henderson “claimed to have known in advance that every memorandum he sent to the White House would find its way immediately through Niles to the Zionists,” confirming the existence of these insiders acting as conduits into the Oval Office. Crucially, these conduits were not simply bringing in demands for Jewish statehood, but also establishing the Palestine question as a moral one, giving Truman political reasons, often under the guise of a humanitarian one. The Weizmann meeting illustrates this perfectly: Chaim Weizmann, the “spiritual” leader of the Zionist movement, secured a private audience with Truman through Niles and persuaded Truman to keep the Negev desert for the Jews. Without issuing direct instructions, Truman made it plain to Hilldring. Nothing should be done to “upset the apple cart,” Truman admonished. Personal connections deepened the network; Eddie Jacobson, Truman’s former business partner, “did not belong to any Zionist organization, but he shared the dream of a national homeland and wanted to be helpful in the cause ... eventually as the quasi ambassador of the new state of Israel.” Truman himself understood this connection was created, and “was obliged to maneuver between a growing, aggressive Zionist lobby allied with his own White House advisors and a State Department which was unequivocally opposed to Zionism.” The network of Jewish-aligned White House advisors – Niles, Clifford, and Lowenthal – proved to be some of the most influential instruments in advancing the cause of Jewish statehood, ensuring that the arguments reached Truman quickly and were framed in a favourable light. While the insiders were winning their moral arguments within the Oval Office, the State Department’s opposition was concretizing around geopolitical concerns.

Much of the State Department’s opposition to the partition lay within the ties and dependencies Americans had in conjunction with the Arab threats of military and oil sanctions. The Arab Higher Committee had made itself clear, stating that “any attempt to impose a solution contrary to the Arabs’ birthright will lead to trouble, bloodshed, and probably a third world war.” Considering the repercussions American foreign policy faced after World War II, even the threat of another global conflict to that scale was unacceptable. King ‘Abd al-Aziz of Saudi Arabia escalated the tension, menacing war against the United States should it deploy forces in Palestine to support Jewish immigration, whilst simultaneously threatening oil sanctions against American oil interests in the region, namely AR-

AMCO. The State Department, spearheaded by Marshall, Henderson, and Lovett, immediately saw these threats as a validation of its concerns. Henderson regarded the partition as “a recipe for war and, in the event of U.S. support for partition, a guarantor of ‘long-term Arab hostility’”; considering the previous mentions of economic sanctions, the department saw an unyielding case against recognition.

Truman was unfazed. When Secretary of Defense James Forrestal said that the U.S. could not afford to lose Saudi Arabian oil, Truman snapped that he would not act based on oil but on “what is right.” The bluntness was intentional. His private correspondence with Jacobson in February of 1948 reveals a president frustrated equally by both sides of the pressure, noting that “the Jews are so emotional, and the Arabs are so difficult to talk with that it is almost impossible to get anything done.” Neither the Arab military provocations nor the oil threats shook Truman. His dismissal of the Arab threats adds to his documented frustration with AZEC’s tactics, suggesting that his recognition of Israel was not surrendering to AZEC, but him showing his presidential power over his split-minded administration and Marshall’s explicit warning.

After the UNGA voted 33-13-10, passing Resolution 181(II) and therefore the partition of Palestine into an Arab and Jewish state on November 29, 1947, the statehood advocacy and State Department opposition only increased; the former deliberately provoking Truman, the latter outright sabotaging him. Following the United States’ vote in favor, Silver quickly claimed credit, declaring that the AZEC had “marshaled our forces ... converged on the government and induced the president to assert the authority of his administration to overcome the negative attitude of the State Department.” Yet, behind Silver’s boisterous celebration hid a provocation, one that cast the outcome of the vote as a submission to AZEC’s demands, an implication Truman resented deeply, and steeled Truman’s mind that whatever recognition he gave would be on his own terms, not AZEC’s.

While the vote appeared to represent a deeply rooted American stance, the State Department was already maneuvering to reverse its effects. Though to public perception, Truman’s support was “consistent with his earlier efforts to secure admission of Jewish DPs to Palestine,” while “the State Department pursued its policy, silently hoping that the UN would finally fail.” Just eighteen days after the UNGA vote, the State Department circulated an internal report recommending that “the United States should immediately announce that we have become convinced that the partition of Palestine is impossible of implementation and that the Palestine problem should therefore be referred back to a special session of the General Assembly to meet in a neutral country such as Switzerland.” This

report directly contradicted the vote the United States delegates had cast only a few weeks earlier. This covert opposition broke into the public on March 19, 1948, when US Senator Warren Austin addressed the Security Council, calling for “the immediate convening of a special session of the General Assembly to institute a temporary trusteeship for Palestine,” reversing American policy in full public view without Truman’s permission. This episode made it clear to Truman that his real opposition was not the lobby he was alleged to be serving but his own State Department acting against his policy, a confrontation Marshall could no longer delay.

Two days before Israel declared independence, the tensions between Truman and the State Department reached their apex. On May 12, 1948, Truman had a meeting in the Oval Office to resolve the recognition question, considering the expiration of the British Mandate on May 15th. Marshall and his undersecretary, Robert Lovett, came in prepared to argue for a delay, while Clifford came to advocate for immediate recognition. Marshall was visibly angered when he saw Clifford in the room. “Mr. President,” he said, “I thought this meeting was called to consider an important and complicated problem in foreign policy. I don’t even know why Clifford is here. He is a domestic adviser, and this is a foreign policy matter.” To Marshall, Clifford’s presence confirmed his suspicion that a decision had already been made on electoral grounds, and that Clifford’s advice was equivalent to “a transparent dodge to win a few votes” at the expense of “the great dignity of the office of the President.” In response, Marshall delivered the boldest claim ever directed at a sitting president, bluntly stating that “if the President were to follow Mr. Clifford’s advice” and “if in the elections [he] were to vote, [he] would vote against the President.” However, the confrontation did not end there. The day of the Israel’s declaration of independence, Lovett warned that recognition would cause “a tremendous reaction . . . in the Arab world,” and requested a single-day extension to notify American embassies across Arab countries. Without even referring the request to Truman, Clifford outright rejected the delay. Marshall, on his side, ultimately followed the president’s orders and proceeded with the recognition. He sent a telegram to London, crossing out the word “limited” from the recognition language, but his compliance could not erase what had happened. Truman overrode his own Secretary of State, resisted unprecedented threats in American foreign policy history, and proceeded with his own judgment.

When Truman famously gave Israel his formal recognition on May 14th, 1948, eleven minutes after its founding, the timing of his recognition revealed a man who had long been set on his decision. The most telling detail of this entire episode is his hand-

written alteration of the White House Draft Release. He crossed out “Jewish State” and instead wrote “State of Israel,” revealing intentionality, and changing it from a religious/ethnic name to a political entity with true sovereignty, showing that Truman recognized a country, not a movement. The recognition was intentionally confined. The White House statement read: “The United States recognizes the provisional government as the de facto authority of the new ~~[[strickethrough]]~~ Jewish state~~[[/strickethrough]]~~ State of Israel.” The legal distinction between de facto and de jure plays a crucial role in Truman’s statement. By recognizing Israel only as de facto, Truman deliberately left ambiguity on borders, the control of Jerusalem, and internal governance, refusing to hand Ben-Gurion’s provisional government a *carte blanche*. He enforced this restricted scope by imposing conditions on democratic elections, stating that “when a permanent government was elected in Israel, it would promptly be given de jure recognition.” Israel held those elections on January 25, 1949 and just six days later, the United States extended full diplomatic recognition: “The United States Government is therefore pleased to extend de jure recognition to the Government of Israel as of this date.” Truman structured recognition as a reward for democratic governance, not as a submission to pro-Zionist advocacy. Across the edited release, the deliberate de facto scope, the de jure condition tied to elections, and his verifiable rejection of lobbying throughout 1946-47, one pattern persists: Truman registered all external pressure – Silver, Marshall, the Arab states – to set his own terms.

Recognition of Israel underscored a turning point that had implications stretching far beyond May 14, 1948. Silver and AZEC, Marshall and the State Department, and Truman’s moral principles each hold their own parts of the truth. But when analysing them standalone, none account for Truman crossing out “Jewish State,” his deliberately limiting the scope of recognition to de facto, or his willingness to act in defiance of his own Secretary of State. The “constant barrage” – composed of Clifford, Niles, Lowenthal, and Jacobson – working alongside Silver and AZEC only steeled Truman’s resolve. The recognition of Israel was Truman strategically demonstrating his presidential power on his own terms, refusing to submit to one group of advocates.

Silver had long cast the UNGA partition as a triumph for the AZEC’s lobby, a characterization of Truman that easily adapted into the popular narrative, letting “group-think and confirmation bias” solidify into “consistent techniques in maintaining a pro-Zionist paradigm for the policy-making elites of the U.S. government.” Yet, when reflecting on presidential administrations and their relationship with Israel, the story is anything but uniform. In 1956, following the Suez crisis, Eisenhower forced Israel to withdraw from the

Sinai Peninsula by pressuring Ben-Gurion through the cutoff of American private financial support. In 1991, George H. W. Bush delayed \$10 billion in U.S. loan guarantees to pressure Israel into halting West Bank settlement construction and participating in the Madrid Peace Conference. In 2015, Obama argued with Prime Minister Netanyahu ardently over Iranian nuclear deals, and even abstained from the UNSC Resolution 2334 vote, flagging Israeli settlements in the West Bank as “flagrant violation under international law”. In 2018, Trump reversed the course, moving the U.S. embassy to Jerusalem, and signed a proclamation officially recognizing Israeli sovereignty over the Golan Heights after 50 years of U.S. policy viewing the area as occupied territory. Biden, in response to the October 7 attacks in 2023, called American support for Israel “rock solid and unwavering,” but then withheld heavy-bomb shipments bound for Israel. Each president has had their version of the three-way balance Truman first had: an organized lobby, administrative caution, and executive judgment, on his own terms. Recognition planted a seed for a durable partnership, not a *carte blanche*; one still shaped by the tensions Truman navigated in 1948.

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